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NATION

INSIDE ZAMFARA COMMUNITIES PAYING FOR...

After an attack on a military base in Maru LGA, a bandit leader imposed a N50m...

PAGE 2

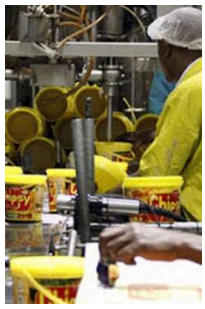


ECONOMY

SMUGGLED IMPORTS AND COSTLY LOANS HURTING LOCAL...

Kano industrialist Halifa Bala Rabiu says smuggled goods, especially edible...

PAGE 4



EDUCATION

REPEATED STRIKES HAVE COST FCT PUPILS OVER 180...

Parents in Abuja say teachers' strikes have pushed them into paying for lessons...

PAGE 5



POLITICS

STATE POLICE: 25 ASSEMBLIES APPROVE AMENDMENT, PASSING TWO-THIRDS MARK

Twenty-five state assemblies have now approved the constitutional amendment for state police, more than the 24 required, says Chief of Staff Femi Gbajabiamila.

By Today Newspaper Staff

ABUJA — Twenty-five of Nigeria's 36 state Houses of Assembly have approved the constitutional amendment that would allow states to establish their own police, passing the two-thirds threshold required by the Constitution.



Continues on page 3

MORE TOP STORIES

RMD to Deliver Keynote at PAO Digital Content Regulation Conference



PAGE 6

Tinubu Takes 2027 Campaign to Kaduna



PAGE 3

Macron's State Visit to Nigeria Called Off, Business Forum Postponed

PAGE 3

NATION

Malaria Rate Among Children Falls to 15.2%, Survey Shows

PAGE 2

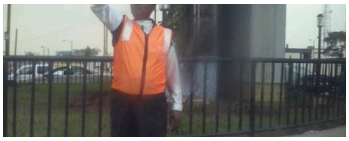
NATION

Customs Says Applicants Who Used 'Backdoor' Were Removed From Recruitme...

PAGE 2

ECONOMY

FG, Bi-Courtney Settle 19-Year Dispute Over Lagos Airport Terminal Two



PAGE 4

ECONOMY

OPay Targets Up to $4.4bn Valuation in US Stock Market Listing



PAGE 4

NATION

INSIDE ZAMFARA COMMUNITIES PAYING FOR BANDITS' REPRISALS



GUSAU — Residents of communities in Dansadau Emirate, Maru Local Government Area of Zamfara State, say they are bearing the cost of reprisal attacks by bandits, according to a field report by Premium Times.

On 5 October, a bandit leader known as Dankarami Gwaska attacked a military base and mining sites in Bindin ward, killing 14 soldiers and mobile police officers and looting the armoury. He then demanded a N50 million "protection levy" from the area. Residents say about N360 million was extorted within two weeks and that almost everyone has fled.

Another gang leader, known as Rambo, demanded N50 million and the return of weapons seized by vigilantes, and planted explosives on the Magami–Dansadau road. The army spokesperson, Aliyu Danja, said troops cleared the devices on 9 October. A day later, an escorted convoy was ambushed on the same road.

A community leader, Nuhu Babangida, blamed the reprisals on vigilante attacks and accused politicians of stoking insecurity at election time. The police spokesperson in the state could not be reached for comment.

Malaria Rate Among Children Falls to 15.2%, Survey Shows

ABUJA — The share of children aged six months to five years infected with malaria in Nigeria fell from 22 per cent in 2021 to 15.2 per cent in 2025, according to the 2025 Nigeria Malaria Indicator Survey.

The survey and the National Malaria Strategic Plan 2026–2030 were launched in Abuja on Thursday. Speaking through the Permanent Secretary, Daju Kachollom, the Coordinating Minister of Health, Professor Muhammad Ali Pate, welcomed the progress but warned that the disease has not been eliminated. The new plan aims to halve malaria prevalence and deaths by 2030.

Kebbi State recorded one of the largest falls, from 49 per cent to 18 per cent. In households with treated nets, 72.3 per cent of children and 80.6 per cent of pregnant women slept under one. The national coordinator of the malaria programme, Dr Nnenna Ogbulafor, called for more domestic funding.

Customs Says Applicants Who Used 'Backdoor' Were Removed From Recruitment List

ABUJA — The Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) says some applicants protesting their removal from its recruitment list had tried to use "backdoor channels" and that anyone dropped by mistake will be reinstated.

The service's spokesperson, Abdullahi Maiwada, said 397 applicants were disqualified at the physical screening for reasons including drug use, age, fitness and documents. He said appearing on the list did not guarantee employment.

The Federal Character Commission has called for the exercise to be suspended, saying it was not invited to monitor it. In July, the service named 3,852 successful candidates out of 573,680 applicants, and the Comptroller-General, Adewale Adeniyi, said places were shared equally among the 36 states.

POLITICS

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

State Police: 25 Assemblies Approve Amendment, Passing Two-Thirds Mark

The Chief of Staff to the President, Femi Gbajabiamila, who chairs the Presidential Working Group on the National Policing Bill, disclosed this in a statement. The assemblies yet to approve the Constitution (Sixth Alteration) Bill 2026 are Lagos, Ondo, Ebonyi, Kogi, Niger, Borno, Bauchi, Jigawa, Katsina, Kano and Sokoto.

The draft National Policing Bill and 29 related amendment bills were sent to the Attorney-General of the Federation on 19 October for a drafting review and are due back by 30 October. Gbajabiamila has described the policing bill as the most important bill of the administration so far.

The amendment, passed by the Senate on 24 June and the House of Representatives on 23 July, was sent to the states on 16 September. It creates a Federal Police Service and state police services under a new section of the Constitution, and allows the President to take over a state police service in defined circumstances.

The amendment still needs presidential assent. The National Policing Bill must then be passed, and each state must enact its own law before any state police force can begin operating. President Bola Tinubu set up the working group on 7 July 2026.

Tinubu Takes 2027 Campaign to Kaduna



KADUNA — President Bola Tinubu, the presidential candidate of the All Progressives Congress (APC), is due to begin the northern leg of his 2027 campaign on Saturday at the Kaduna Township Stadium, with all seven North-West governors expected to attend.

Campaigning for the presidential and National Assembly elections opened on 19 August and runs until 15 January 2027, according to the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC).

The choice of Kaduna has drawn debate. Critics point to insecurity in the state, the detention of former governor Nasir El-Rufai and anti-government chants heard at some northern gatherings. Tinubu lost Kaduna to Atiku Abubakar in the 2023 election. Supporters say the city remains the political centre of the North. The APC's publicity secretary in the state, Mohammed Sani Haruna, cited its history as the former capital of the Northern Region and Governor Uba Sani's ties to the President.

Former Defence Minister Muhammad Badaru Abubakar, who leads the Arewa for Asiwaju group, said it planned to bring more than 10,000 supporters from the 19 northern states and the FCT. The Kaduna police spokesperson, DSP Mansir Hassan, said several security agencies had been deployed and some roads would be closed.

Macron's State Visit to Nigeria Called Off, Business Forum Postponed

ABUJA — A state visit to Nigeria by French President Emmanuel Macron, planned for Wednesday, 28 October, has been called off, Premium Times reported, citing Nigerian officials.

According to the sources, Macron and President Bola Tinubu agreed on Thursday to cancel the trip. Reasons cited include the protests that have disrupted France since September, the approach of Nigeria's presidential election in about three months, and the recently confirmed Ebola case in Nigeria. The French Embassy declined to comment, while the spokesperson for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Olufemi Adeniyi, said the ministry had no such information and would announce any official change.

On Saturday, the France-Nigeria Business Council informed participants by email that its business forum, scheduled for 29 October in Lagos, had been postponed. The email said the two presidents had jointly decided to postpone the state visit, which is now expected in 2027, and that a new date for the forum would be announced.

The visit was meant to return President Tinubu's three-day state visit to France in 2024.

ECONOMY

SMUGGLED IMPORTS AND COSTLY LOANS HURTING LOCAL MANUFACTURERS, SAYS HALBA FOODS CHIEF



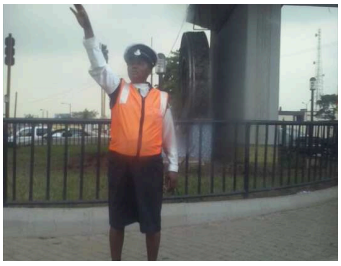
KANO — The Managing Director of Halba Foods, Halifa Bala Rabiu, says smuggled imports and difficult access to credit are among the biggest threats facing Nigerian manufacturers.

In an interview with ThisDay, the Kano-based industrialist said imported finished goods, especially smuggled edible oil, undercut products made in the country. He called for stronger border enforcement but said the problem could not be blamed on the government alone, as many parties are involved.

Halba's rice mill in Kano has a capacity of 60 tonnes a day, and its edible oil packaging line 20,000 litres a day. The company plans to introduce 500g and 1kg rice packs for low-income buyers, and is considering maize flour, instant noodles and drinks with foreign partners, as well as exports to neighbouring countries such as Niger.

On financing, Rabiu said banks rely too heavily on collateral. If a business already had collateral worth N1 billion to secure a N600 million loan, he argued, it would hardly need the loan in the first place.

FG, Bi-Courtney Settle 19-Year Dispute Over Lagos Airport Terminal Two



LAGOS — The Federal Government, the Federal Airports Authority of Nigeria (FAAN), Bi-Courtney Ltd and Stabilini Visinoni Ltd have signed a settlement ending a dispute of more than 18 years over Terminal Two of Murtala Muhammed Airport (MMA2) in Lagos.

Speaking at the signing, the chairman of Bi-Courtney Aviation Services, Dr Wale Babalakin (SAN), credited President Bola Tinubu's intervention through the Minister of Aviation and Aerospace Development, Festus Keyamo (SAN). "This is not a win for us alone; it is a win for Nigerians," he said, and promised that the company would create jobs.

The agreement opens the way for a hotel and conference centre at MMA2, regional flights from the terminal and an expanded apron. It also settles issues over the General Aviation Terminal, which remains under FAAN, and revises the obligations of both sides under the concession.

OPay Targets Up to $4.4bn Valuation in US Stock Market Listing



LAGOS — Mobile payments company OPay is seeking a valuation of up to $4.42 billion in its planned listing in the United States, the company said on Friday.

According to Reuters, OPay plans to raise up to $366 million by selling about 16 million American Depositary Shares priced between $19 and $21 each.

The company was founded in 2018 by Chinese billionaire Yahui Zhou, who also founded Beijing Kunlun Tech. Besides Nigeria, it operates in Indonesia, Egypt and Pakistan. OPay raised $400 million in 2021 at a valuation of $2 billion, and its listing documents put its monthly active users at about 50 million as of 31 July.

The offer comes as demand for new listings in the US is under pressure from higher inflation and a sell-off in technology stocks.

EDUCATION

REPEATED STRIKES HAVE COST FCT PUPILS OVER 180 SCHOOL DAYS SINCE 2023



ABUJA — Pupils in public primary schools in the Federal Capital Territory have lost more than 180 school days to at least six major strikes since September 2023, according to a Weekend Trust special report.

The latest strike by FCT workers began on 7 October and was suspended on 20 October, with teachers told to return to class on 21 October. A strike from March to July 2025 ended only after the six area councils released N16 billion.

Parents interviewed said they had paid for private lessons, moved children to private schools or sent them to learn trades during the strikes. The FCT chairman of the Nigeria Union of Teachers, Abdullahi Mohammed Shafas, rejected a rule linking promotions to available vacancies and denied that the strikes were political. The FCT Administration did not respond to requests for comment. Education experts warned that repeated strikes would push more children out of school.

IGP Urges Schools to Put Prevention First on Safety



LAGOS — The Inspector-General of Police, Tunji Disu, has urged schools to put prevention at the centre of their safety plans, with intelligence gathering, early warning systems, emergency drills and prompt reporting of threats.

He spoke through the Lagos State Commissioner of Police, Tijani Fatai, at a summit of the Education Writers Association of Nigeria (EWAN) on the theme "School Safety: A National Security Priority".

The association's chairman, Mojeed Alabi, recalled the Chibok and Dapchi abductions and urged journalists to check whether schools have working emergency systems and how school security funds are spent.

ENTERTAINMENT

RMD TO DELIVER KEYNOTE AT PAO DIGITAL CONTENT REGULATION CONFERENCE



LAGOS — Veteran actor Richard Mofe-Damijo (RMD) will deliver the keynote address at the sixth International Peace Anyiam-Osigwe (PAO) Nigeria Digital Content Regulation Conference, to be held in Lagos on 18 and 19 November 2026.

The theme of the conference is "Film and Content Production in the Digital Era: Balancing Regulation and Innovation". According to the National Film and Video Censors Board (NFVCB), he follows Mo Abudu (2024) and Bolanle Austen-Peters (2025) as keynote speaker.

Mofe-Damijo has featured in more than 60 film and television productions. A former journalist and founder of RMD Productions, he also served as Delta State Commissioner for Culture and Tourism. The NFVCB Executive Director, Dr Shaibu Husseini, welcomed his acceptance.

AFRIFF 2026 to Open With Olive Nwosu's Debut Feature 'Lady'



LAGOS — The 15th Africa International Film Festival (AFRIFF) will open in Lagos on 1 November with "Lady", the first feature film by Olive Nwosu, and run until 7 November under the theme "Frames of the Future: Africa's Creative Intelligence".

"Lady" follows a young Lagos taxi driver who drives sex workers on their night rounds, one of whom is a childhood friend. The festival will close with "It's the Blackness", the directorial debut of actor Hakeem Kae-Kazim, produced by Dapo Oshiyemi, a comedy-drama about two friends, Eniola and Jordan.

The festival's founder, Chioma Ude, said African cinema is entering an exciting new chapter. The programme includes screenings, masterclasses and the Africa Film and Content Market.

Jagun Jagun 2 Adds K1, Pasuma and Funke Akindele to Cast



LAGOS — Femi Adebayo's epic "Jagun Jagun 2: The War of Warriors" will be released on 4 December 2026, with Fuji stars King Wasiu Ayinde Marshall (K1 De Ultimate) and Wasiu Alabi Pasuma, as well as actress Funke Akindele, joining the cast.

Several actors from the first film, including Odunlade Adekola, Lateef Adedimeji and Bimbo Ademoye, are expected to return. Adebayo said on social media that the sequel took two years of relentless work.

The first "Jagun Jagun" won two awards at the 2024 Africa Magic Viewers' Choice Awards, for Best Indigenous Language Movie (West Africa) and Best Costume Design, and three awards at the 2024 Africa Movie Academy Awards.

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